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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

‘I’m afraid this time’

Deportation fears spur church to end Spanish services

By Laura Rodríguez Presa
Chicago Tribune

The church pews where Francisca Lino and her family had sat for services every Sunday are now empty. Though she once sought sanctuary in the Chicago church to avoid deportation, this time “not even that holy space feels safe,” she said.

Instead, Lino, a mother of six and wife of a U.S. citizen, plans to gather her family in front of a computer to watch a Spanish-language service at Lincoln United Methodist Church virtually every Sunday from now on.

“My family and I are tired of this,” said Lino, whose Christmas was once again overshadowed by the uncertainty of her and her family’s future in the country.

After the threats from the incoming Trump administration that Chicago will be the epicenter of mass deportations, Emma Lozano, an activist and pastor at Lincoln United Methodist, decided to move its Spanish services online as the church prepares to protect its undocumented immigrant community. The services in English will remain in-person.

The Pilsen church, Lozano said, has been vandalized and attacked by right-wing extremists in the past.

“We must take their threats seriously and prepare for the worst,” Lozano said.

That fear is beginning to settle in amid the immigrant community in the Chicago area. Advocates and local leaders warn that mass deportations could affect undocumented, mixed-status and new migrant families alike. Even if that is the case, the Mexican community is expected to experience the most deportations,

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Authorities investigating assault in New Orleans’ French Quarter as act of terror

FBI hunts for other suspects as Army vet with IS flag dies in shootout with police

AT LEAST 15 DEAD IN TRUCK ATTACK



Emergency personnel work the scene after a man drove into a crowd in New Orleans’ French Quarter on Wednesday. **GERALD HERBERT/AP**

By Eric Tucker,
Jim Mustian,
Kevin McGill
and Jack Brook
Associated Press

NEW ORLEANS — An Army veteran driving a pickup truck that bore the flag of the Islamic State group wrought carnage on New Orleans’ raucous New Year’s celebration, killing at least 15 people as he steered around a police blockade and hit revelers before being shot dead by police.

The FBI said it is investigating the attack early Wednesday in the famed French Quarter as a terrorist act and does not believe

the driver acted alone.

President Joe Biden said Wednesday night the FBI found videos that the driver posted to social media hours before the attack in which he said he was inspired by the Islamic State group and expressed a desire to kill.

Investigators found multiple improvised explosive devices, including two pipe bombs concealed within coolers and wired for remote detonation, according to a Louisiana State Police intelligence bulletin obtained by The Associated Press.

The bulletin also said surveillance footage

showed three men and a woman placing one of the devices, but federal officials did not confirm that detail, and it wasn’t clear who the individuals in the video were or what connection they may have had to the attack.

The rampage turned festive Bourbon Street into macabre mayhem.

In addition to the dead, more than 30 people were injured, authorities said.

Pedestrians fled to safety inside nightclubs and restaurants.

One man watched in horror as authorities placed a tarp over his friend’s body after she was hit and

thrown some 30 feet.

A college football playoff game between Georgia and Notre Dame at the nearby Superdome was postponed until Thursday. A Georgia student was critically hurt in the attack, university President Jere Morehead said.

“This is not just an act of terrorism. This is evil,” New Orleans Police Superintendent Anne Kirkpatrick said. The driver “defeated” safety measures in place to protect pedestrians, she said, and was “hell-bent on creating the carnage and the damage that he did.”

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VEHICLES AS WEAPONS:

The assault is the latest in a long string of vehicle-based attacks against crowds, dating back decades. Vehicle ramming did not start as a terrorist tactic, but it has frequently been used by extremist organizations and radicalized individuals to kill, injure and instill fear. **Nation & World**

INSIDE



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

City’s Ecuadorians celebrate Mass, community

Members of the Ecuadorian community held a procession for the Virgin Mary through the streets of Albany Park on Wednesday, commemorating a religious holiday and a cultural touchstone with special significance for immigrants. The feast of Nuestra Señora Virgen de la Nube, or the Virgin of the Cloud, is celebrated in villages throughout Ecuador and Peru, and marks a once-a-year chance for immigrants here to share their faith with traditional music, dancing and food. **Chicagoland**, Page 5

HOPES FOR HOOPS: Eight New Year’s resolutions for the city’s basketball teams, including the Bulls’ front office finally coming to a decision on Zach LaVine after two years of dillydallying and the Sky working to improve their frontcourt. **Chicago Sports**

Suit against wetlands program could have ‘nationwide’ effect

By Karina Atkins
Chicago Tribune

John Gilbert’s father spent years trying to convert a flood-prone patch of land on their nearly 800-acre farm in Hardin County, Iowa, to more cropland.

“We fought with that land for many years,” said Gilbert, now in his mid-70s. But it was always only a matter of time before heavy rain made it impossible to grow crops. “Some land just isn’t meant to be farmed.”

The Gilbert family stopped fighting nature in the 1990s, shortly after the introduction of the Wetland Conservation provisions in the 1985 Farm Bill. Known as Swamp-

buster, the federal program requires farmers to conserve wetlands to be eligible for federal farm subsidies, loans and insurance.

The voluntary program encourages Gilbert and many farmers across the country to preserve ecosystems that act as natural flood controls, water quality managers and habitats for native species. His family converted the patch back to grassland and uses it to graze cattle, a move that has improved soil health and mitigated flooding in the long term.

But a federal lawsuit brought before a district court in Iowa by a Chicago investor and two libertar-

ian law firms based in Texas and California in April aims to abolish Swampbuster. It’s one of the federal government’s last mechanisms to safeguard wetlands, whose protections have been severely curtailed over the last decade by the first Trump administration and conservative Supreme Court justices just as climate change makes them more necessary.

Thirty million acres of unprotected wetlands in the upper Midwest, including over 640,000 in Iowa and 1 million in Illinois, are at risk of being destroyed, according to a new study by the

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“This may seem like a small stream in Iowa that’s really far away, but the impact is not only for my local community and my local environment. This is eventually going to the Mississippi River and down to the Gulf of Mexico.”

— Elle Gadiant, who owns a farm downstream from the land at the center of the case

